A Keepsake of You

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A Keepsake of You

by Lunaeryi

Summary

Phainon was on his way to help a friend. He ended up accidentally flirting with a grumpy shopkeeper, buying a cursed locket, and possibly selling his soul. Oops.

Notes

Didn’t plan on posting today but there isn’t much you can do when you’re sick and chained to your house like a Victorian Maiden in the 1800’s😭

See the end of the work for more notes

The rain hadn’t let up for hours. A thin, misting drizzle clung to everything, softening the edges of the streetlights and giving the cracked pavement a slick, glassy sheen. Phainon pulled the collar of his jacket higher, ignoring how the fabric stuck uncomfortably to the side of his neck. It wasn’t the kind of night meant for wandering.

And yet, here he was.

He was supposed to be headed toward Hyacine’s apartment two blocks down—a friend, sweet as sugar and twice as easy to worry about. She was a medic, the kind that gave too much of herself and forgot to rest, and Phainon had promised to drop by and patch up her kitchen window, which had apparently lost the fight against a rowdy storm. Not exactly his area of expertise, but he was good with his hands and better at making people smile, so it was enough.

He would’ve made it too. Should’ve. But then there was *that smell.*

It curled through the air like an old memory, dragging warmth behind it in thin, ephemeral threads. Woodsmoke. Not the clean kind that clung to winter jackets and fireplaces, but deeper—older. There was something sweeter in it, a barely-there undercurrent of dried herbs, amber, and the faint metallic tang of rain-soaked earth. It clung to his senses in a way scents never did, stirring up some ache behind his ribs he couldn’t quite name.

Gods…what *is* that?

He slowed at the mouth of a narrow alley, a place so easy to miss it was like it had grown out of the brick and shadow itself. Half the flickering neon signs on the street didn’t even seem to register its existence. Phainon frowned, fingers flexing at his side, caught between common sense and the quiet, bone-deep pull of that scent.

“Five minutes,” he murmured to himself. “Hyacine won’t skin me for five.”

His boots splashed shallow puddles as he stepped inside, the world muffling around him. The alley was tight, claustrophobic, lined with crumbling stone

and ancient brickwork patched over with rusting iron fixtures. At its end hung a single, weather-worn sign.

Castrum Kelethra.

The letters were etched in tarnished brass, warped from age and exposure, edges dulled by countless storms. The sign hung from an old iron bracket, swaying slightly in the damp air though there wasn't any wind.

The storefront itself was small and half-swallowed by creeping ivy, window glass fogged from within, warped by age so the objects behind it bled into each other in indistinct shapes. A single brass lantern hung above the door, its flame flickering weakly as if struggling to hold its place in the world.

Phainon hesitated at the threshold. The scent was stronger here, wrapping around him in gentle, insistent waves. It wasn't just smoke anymore. There was warmth in it, something like *old paper*, like the heavy hush of forgotten attics and ink stains left on fingertips.

His palm hovered over the doorknob, slick with rain.

"This is probably a terrible idea," he told himself, though the grin curling his mouth said he wasn't half as convinced as he should be.

The brass handle was warm when his fingers closed around it.

The door gave under his touch with a soft scrape, opening into a space that felt…oddly heavy. Not dusty or cluttered the way old shops sometimes were, but heavy in a way that settled over the skin and lodged somewhere in the throat.

The brass bells mounted above the door gave a sharp, bright chime. Phainon glanced up to see them completely still.

He stepped inside.

The air hung thick with the scent that had drawn him here—smoke, yes, but deeper now, layered with wax, brittle herbs, and the dry, acidic note of something long gone to rot. It tasted on his tongue like candlewax and grief.

Shadows gathered in the corners of the room, not quite behaving like they should. The light flickered in the wrong places, casting long, distorted shapes against the walls where there were none.

Phainon let the door swing shut behind him, the outside world muffled to a soft hush. His gaze moved over the space slowly. Shelves lined the walls, laden with bottles in every imaginable shape and color, glasswork so old it shimmered like oil beneath the low lamplight. Framed lockets hung in careful rows behind the counter, and in the far corner sat a small display of delicate trinkets glinting in the gloom.

It felt like a place outside of time. The kind of place you might stumble into and forget the way out.

He took a few more steps in, absently reaching out to trace the edge of a carved wooden box, when a voice cut through the quiet like a knife.

“Buy something or get out.”

Phainon startled—just a little—and turned toward the counter.

A man sat behind it, hunched over a cluttered workbench, tools spread out around him in neat, obsessive rows. The light caught on the edge of pale, messy hair, and the steady, precise movement of his hands as he worked on something too small to make out. He didn’t even bother to lift his head when he spoke.

Phainon grinned despite himself. *Ah, there it is.*

“Charming place you’ve got here,” he said, letting his voice settle into its usual easy warmth. He stepped closer, hands stuffed casually into his jacket pockets. “Didn’t mean to intrude. Just…caught a scent outside. Couldn’t help myself.”

Nothing.

Not so much as a glance.

Undeterred, Phainon chuckled under his breath and leaned against the counter's edge. "Got a name, or should I just keep calling you handsome in my head?"

A pause. The scraping of metal against glass stilled for half a second, and finally, the man looked up.

His eyes were a sharp, pale yellow—expression flat and unreadable, the kind of look people usually gave a stubborn stain on the floor. His mouth didn't move, didn't so much as twitch.

"I don't care what you call me," he said evenly. "You're still not touching anything."

Phainon didn't push further.

He got the message—low conversation tolerance, no patience for charm. Fine. He could take a hint. Still, now that he was here…

His gaze drifted across the shelves, fingers twitching at his sides with the urge to pick something up just to see how the shopkeeper would react.

Lockets. Perfume. Small bottles arranged in precise color gradations—amber to bloodred to smoke-black—each with a tiny strip of handwritten vellum tied around its neck. There were fragments of chain coiled in bowls like serpents, bronze and silver and darker metals that didn't seem to catch the light at all. Some of the lockets were empty, open-faced and waiting. Others were sealed with dark glass and etched symbols he didn't recognize.

"Lockets and…perfume?" he said aloud, more to himself than anyone, his voice light with curiosity. "What an odd combo."

The shopkeeper didn't answer. A muscle in his jaw twitched, barely perceptible.

Right. Still not the chatty type.

Phainon held both hands up, fingers splayed in mock surrender. "Alright, alright—I'll buy something, don't worry. I just…" he trailed off, glancing

helplessly at the shelves. “I have no idea *what*.”

He stood there awkwardly for a beat too long, hands slowly lowering. The silence stretched again, like it had weight.

Then—without ceremony, without even looking up—the shopkeeper reached over to a carved wooden tray beside his elbow and picked something out with gloved fingers.

A thin strip of paper, shaped like a teardrop. Slightly yellowed. The edges were scalloped with something that looked scorched.

He held it out without glancing over. “Here.”

Phainon stepped forward and took it carefully, raising one brow as he brought it closer to his nose. “You do samples too? Fancy.”

The shopkeeper still didn’t look at him.

He breathed in.

For a moment, there was nothing.

Then—

The air left his lungs like he’d been punched. Not physically, not quite, but his mind reeled. The scent hit him so hard it was almost violent. Dry soil after a storm. Smoke rising from distant chimney stacks. The sharpness of birch bark, and the cool, clean wind that used to come down off the mountains in *Aedes Elysiae*, back when the roads were dust and the nights rang with cicadas and the smell of firewood hung in every thread of his coat.

It wasn’t just evocative—it was it.

It dragged the memory straight out of him like a fish on a line. His knees didn’t buckle, but they almost did.

The strip slipped from his fingers and fluttered to the floor.

He stared.

How the hell—

“Interesting choice,” the shopkeeper murmured, still bent over his workbench, like none of it mattered at all.

Phainon blinked down at the fallen paper strip, pulse still rattling unevenly in his throat. He swallowed hard and looked back up.

“What the hell was that?” he asked, voice pitched lower now, less teasing and more rattled than he meant to let on.

The shopkeeper finally raised his head.

Those yellow eyes settled on Phainon, bored, like a cat watching a fly it didn’t feel like chasing. “A sample,” he said flatly.

“No,” Phainon gestured between the strip and himself, “I mean—that. That wasn’t just a nice scent, that was…” he trailed off, searching for a word that didn’t make him sound insane. “That was a whole *memory*.”

The shopkeeper shrugged like it was normal. “You’re welcome.”

Phainon opened his mouth to push a little further, but before he could string the words together, the shopkeeper set his tool down with a soft clink and sighed, the kind of long, bone-deep sigh reserved for people who regretted every life decision that led them to this exact conversation.

“Don’t you have something better to be doing?” He muttered.

It took Phainon a full second to register the words—and then his stomach dropped.

“Shit,” he breathed, patting at his jacket for his phone. He hadn’t even realized how much time had passed. The old brass clock on the far wall ticked in a slow, arrhythmic beat. He was at least ten minutes late. Maybe more.

“Shit, shit—Hyacine’s gonna kill me.”

Without another word, he made for the door, sparing one last glance at the pale, irritable man behind the counter who had already gone back to his work like nothing had happened.

The bells above the door gave another sharp, uncanny chime as he shoved it open and slipped out into the wet night.

The alley was darker than before.

Phainon took two hurried steps before his brain caught up to his legs—and stopped him cold.

Wait.

He turned to look back.

There was no door. No shopfront. No flickering lantern.

Just a long, narrow stretch of crumbling brick wall. Water streaked down it in slow, trembling lines. A stack of broken crates sagged against one corner. The scent of woodsmoke was gone.

“What the…?”

He stepped forward, pressing a hand to the cold, rough wall where the shop had been.

Solid.

There was no way. He’d just been there. The damn bells had rung. He’d talked to—what was his name? Did he even get it?

Phainon opened his mouth to say something to the empty alley when his phone lit up in his hand.

Hyacine calling.

The screen read: *20 minutes late.*

“Shit.”

He hit accept, lifting the phone to his ear as he spun on his heel, moving quickly back toward the main road.

“Hey, hey—I’m so sorry,” he started, forcing a sheepish grin she couldn’t see. “Ran into something weird, I’ll explain later, I’m on my way, swear it.”

His footsteps splashed through the puddles, but just before the alley slipped out of sight behind him, he glanced back one last time.

Still just a wall.

He didn’t know what unnerved him more—the fact that it was gone, or the feeling that *it wasn’t really gone at all.*

Phainon almost hadn’t come.

It’d been weeks since the first time—the night of the woodsmoke and rain, of impossible scents and disappearing doorways. He’d told himself it was a fluke, maybe even a fever dream, a trick of exhaustion and bad weather. But curiosity had a way of getting its hooks into him, and one idle evening too many had found him trailing the streets again, looking for that narrow alley without admitting to himself why.

And there it was.

As though it had always been there. The crooked old sign still hung at an angle, paint faded to a color somewhere between rust and old blood.

Castrum Kelethra.

This time, he hesitated before pushing the door open.

The brass bells above the threshold gave that same unnatural ring—a note that felt like it went through the bones, not the ears. The air inside was no

less heavy. It tasted of old candlewax, cold iron, and something sweetly rancid underneath.

Phainon stepped in cautiously, his hand brushing the back of his neck.

A figure was leaving as he entered—a woman, maybe, though her face was oddly waxen in the low light, the texture of her skin a little too smooth, a little too *wrong*. Her pupils were blown wide, swallowing nearly all the color. She passed him with a stiff, mechanical grace, not a flicker of acknowledgment in her expression.

He shivered.

Don't be paranoid, he told himself.

But he couldn't stop his gaze from following her out the door.

"Back again?"

The voice made him start.

Phainon turned to find the same shopkeeper at the same workbench, his posture a study in boredom, careful hands fiddling with the fine chain of a half-finished locket. No hint of surprise in his voice, no interest either. Just weary, detached recognition.

"You again," the man said.

Phainon forced a grin. "What can I say? Thought I'd see if you had anything new. Also, uh…" He scratched the back of his neck, a little sheepish now. "Kind of made a promise to buy something last time and, well—I'm a man of my word."

The shopkeeper made a noncommittal noise, something between a hum and a sigh.

Phainon let his gaze drift over the display cases again, noting the same eerie little lockets and vials. "So, uh… the lockets," he ventured, moving closer to one of the cases. "They… what, hold pictures? Little keepsakes?"

The man finally looked up from his work.

Yellow eyes, flat as stormclouds.

“They hold memories,” he said simply.

Phainon’s brow furrowed. “Memories?”

The shopkeeper gestured idly to the array of sealed lockets with the tip of his tool. “Moments. Days. People. Preserved forever, like a scent trapped in glass. Open one, and it’s yours to keep. Or someone else’s to steal.”

He said it like it wasn’t the most unsettling explanation Phainon had ever heard.

“That’s…” Phainon started, then caught himself. “Kinda poetic. In a creepy, mildly soul-devouring way.”

A corner of the shopkeeper’s mouth twitched. Not quite a smile. More like the ghost of one.

Phainon tilted his head, leaning his elbow on the nearest glass case. “You gonna tell me your name now or keep me wondering?”

A pause.

Then, uninterested as ever: “Mydei.”

Phainon grinned. “Phainon.”

“I didn’t ask.”

Phainon laughed under his breath. “Yeah, figured.”

But there was something easier in the air now, a slight loosening of the tension, like a coiled wire pulling back a fraction. Not safe, not friendly—but less entirely hostile.

And Phainon, damn fool that he was, found himself even more intrigued.

Phainon gave the shop another slow sweep with his eyes, letting the odd shapes and strange gleams of metal and glass blur together. The place still felt like it was watching him in quiet, expectant ways. Every flicker of a flame, every too-smooth reflection in the glass felt just a little off. But there was something about it that scratched a part of him he couldn’t name.

His gaze caught on a small, simple pendant near the far end of a shelf

—a plain, rounded locket, unadorned, no strange etchings, no glimmer of trapped light inside. Just a smooth, oval surface and a single faint nick along the edge.

Phainon pointed to it. “That one.”

Mydei, still working the fine chain between his fingers, glanced up. His eyes landed on the piece, and for a moment he looked… surprised. Or whatever passed for it on his perpetually unimpressed face.

He snorted under his breath.

“Out of everything in here,” Mydei muttered, “you pick the only normal thing.”

Phainon arched a brow, a smirk tugging at the corner of his mouth. “What’s that supposed to mean?”

Mydei didn’t answer. Just pushed off the workbench, fetched the locket, and placed it in a small, dark cloth pouch with a practiced flick of his wrist.

Phainon decided not to press.

He took the pouch when it was offered, their fingers brushing briefly. The contact was cold, but not unpleasant. Like frostbitten silver.

Phainon slipped the pouch into his jacket pocket.

“Well, Mydei,” he said as he made for the door, casting one last glance over his shoulder, “nice to meet you.”

The bells above the door chimed sharp as he stepped out into the damp evening.

Behind him, Mydei said nothing.

It kept happening.

Phainon wasn’t trying, exactly. It was never on purpose. Some days he’d be out running errands, others on his way to meet Hyacine, and somehow—somehow—he’d turn a corner, follow the scent of woodsmoke and candlewax, and find himself standing in front of Castrum Kelethra again.

At first, Mydei had looked visibly irritated, like a stray cat kept sneaking in through the back door. The second time, he flatly told Phainon to buy something again or piss off. The third, he barely acknowledged him.

By the fifth, Mydei had apparently given up.

At this point, Phainon was no longer treated like a customer. More like an unpaid intern who refused to leave. Mydei had started making him restock shelves, move boxes, and once even scrub down a brass display case when a vial exploded in an incident Mydei blamed entirely on him—though Phainon swore it was already cracked.

He didn’t mind.

Truth be told, the place fascinated him. The way the walls seemed to shift when you weren’t looking, the flickering light that never came from any visible source. And, of course, Mydei himself—perpetually grumpy, sharp-tongued, and fine-looking in a way that Phainon never directly commented on, though he did let a few teasing remarks slip here and there, just to watch the man’s reactions.

Today, though, Phainon came prepared.

He strolled in with the familiar chime of the too-sharp bells, dodged a precarious stack of boxes like a man who knew his way around, and made

his way to the counter where Mydei was hunched over a locket, needle-thin tool in hand.

Without a word, Phainon produced a small paper-wrapped pastry from a nearby street vendor and set it on the counter.

“For your sparkling personality,” he grinned.

Mydei didn’t even look up. “I don’t eat sweets.”

Phainon just shrugged, hands in his jacket pockets. “Shame. Thought you could use a little sugar to balance out all that… whatever it is you’ve got going on.”

Mydei made a noncommittal sound, but didn’t throw it away either.

Phainon let himself wander the shop again, tracing familiar shelves and peeking at the odd new additions—a necklace strung with what looked suspiciously like teeth, a bottle of ink so dark it seemed to absorb the light around it.

He was halfway through inspecting a strange little jar labeled *Acheron’s Wake* when the door opened.

A customer stepped in.

Phainon turned, expecting the usual awkward exchange of greetings, but the figure didn’t say a word. Just moved to the counter, pale hand lifting to point at a locket displayed behind the glass.

Mydei didn’t ask which one. Didn’t even glance at what they were pointing to.

He reached under the glass, retrieved it, and placed it in the stranger’s palm. No money exchanged hands. No receipt. The figure turned and left, door chiming in its unnatural, bone-deep tone.

Phainon shivered.

He glanced back at the counter where the pastry still sat, seemingly untouched.

But later—just as he was leaving—Phainon caught it.

A small, neat bite taken out of the edge.

He grinned to himself as he stepped out the door, saying nothing.

It was raining again.

It always seemed to be, when Phainon ended up here.

He was sitting cross-legged on the floor behind the counter, sorting through a small crate of tarnished chains and tiny brass clasps, separating the broken from the usable because, in Mydei's words, *"if you're going to loiter like some street cat, make yourself useful."*

"Anything else you need, boss?" Phainon called up, smiling as he held up a particularly knotted mess of chain. "Or should I start alphabetizing your curses next?"

Mydei didn't look away from the locket he was etching, his long fingers steady, precise. "I could curse you alphabetically right now if you'd like," he muttered.

Phainon grinned. "Tempting offer."

The conversation, as it often did in this strange place, eventually drifted. Somewhere between idle insults and observations about the weather, it took a turn.

"You ever think about it?" Phainon asked, idly untangling a fine silver chain with the ease of someone now professionally skilled at it. "Death, I mean. What happens after."

Mydei made a low sound, neither agreement nor denial.

“More than you’d expect,” the shopkeeper muttered, voice quieter than usual. “Less than I should.”

Phainon leaned his shoulder against the counter’s edge, watching the other man work. The soft scrape of tool against metal filled the air, mixing with the rain against the windows.

“Time’s a funny thing, isn’t it?” Phainon mused. “Some moments stretch forever. Some are gone before you even realize you had them.”

Mydei didn’t respond to that. Not with words. But his gaze flicked up, lingering on Phainon like he was reading something scrawled across his skin that Phainon couldn’t see.

It made the hairs on the back of his neck rise.

He tried to shake it off, returning to the crate—but that’s when he noticed it. A small, slender bottle tucked on a shelf just within reach, its label written in cramped, spidery lettering.

Firstborn’s Last Breath.

Phainon’s brow furrowed. “Hell of a name for a fragrance.”

“Not for sale,” Mydei said without looking up, as though he’d known exactly what Phainon was staring at.

“Didn’t think it was,” Phainon replied, lips quirking into a crooked grin that didn’t quite reach his eyes.

There were other things, too. The lockets. Half-hidden behind dusty glass, some of them faintly…pulsed. A slow, irregular thrum, like the heartbeat of something small and trapped.

And Mydei was still watching him, gaze dark and distant, as if weighing some invisible scale in his head.

Phainon cleared his throat, breaking the silence. “You know, for someone who claims to hate company, you sure let me hang around a lot.”

Mydei shrugged. “Tolerating you is less effort than scraping your corpse off the doorstep.”

“That’s the nicest thing you’ve ever said to me,” Phainon grinned.

Mydei almost—*almost*—smirked.

Phainon furrowed his brow as he rummaged through a wooden box of tiny trinkets, most of them half-rusted and ominous in ways he chose not to dwell on. “Alright, you said it was a brass key… or was it bronze? Kind of small, shaped like—”

“Like this,” a voice murmured low, practically against his ear.

Phainon jolted—not enough to knock the box over, but enough to suck in a sharp breath as Mydei brushed behind him, leaning in with all the careless impatience of someone who wasn’t used to *sharing their damn space*.

His hand reached past Phainon’s shoulder, fingers ghosting his arm for a fraction of a second as he plucked a tiny, ancient-looking key from the pile. The scent of cold metal and smoke clung to him—and something else underneath it Phainon couldn’t place, something rich and heady that curled in his lungs like the memory of a fever dream.

Phainon swallowed, pulse thudding a little too hard in his throat. “Well,” he managed, voice a notch rougher than it should’ve been. “Could’ve just asked me to move, you know.”

Mydei gave an unimpressed hum, eyes flicking to meet his, their faces barely a breath apart before the shopkeeper straightened like it was nothing at all. “Would’ve taken too long.”

Phainon snorted, leaning back on his heels and absolutely *not* dwelling on the warmth lingering against the side of his neck. “You always this charming, or is it just for me?”

“I reserve my worst manners for the persistent,” Mydei muttered, already turning away.

Phainon grinned, forcing his heart to settle back into something resembling a normal rhythm. He could still feel the ghost of a breath against his ear, though, like a heat he didn’t want to admit to.

Maybe it was the shop’s half-suffocating air getting to him.

Yeah. Probably that.

It wasn’t just that one time.

Phainon started noticing it more, little by little.

Every time he stepped foot past that crooked doorway, the thick, incense-heavy air of Castrum Kelethra clung to his skin like damp silk. And each time he inhaled, it hit a little deeper, spun his head just enough to make the floor feel unsteady beneath his feet.

At first, he blamed it on the scents. On whatever strange oils and powders Mydei kept smoldering in the glass burners that hung from the ceiling, catching the light like pale, hollow orbs.

But then there were the touches.

Not real ones.

Not *quite*.

A brush against the back of his neck, a phantom warmth at the corner of his mouth. The kind of sensation you feel when someone’s standing too close behind you, but when he turned, there was never anyone there.

Phainon told himself it was nothing. The air playing tricks. A trick of scent and shadow and too much imagination.

Except it kept happening.

And it kept feeling more like *someone*.

On a rain-hushed evening, he found himself leaning against the counter, half-drunk on whatever cloying air lived inside these walls. Mydei was bent over a workbench, his profile sharp in the flicker of candlelight, eyes catching like frost when they glanced up.

Phainon cleared his throat.

“So,” he began, casual and careless, though his pulse thudded loud in his ears. “Say I wanted one of those lockets.”

Mydei didn’t look up.

“They’re for sale,” the shopkeeper muttered.

“No, I mean… a custom piece.”

The words hung heavy in the space between them.

This time, Mydei did lift his head. His gaze settled on Phainon’s face like the edge of a scalpel—too sharp, too assessing. The silence stretched out long enough to make Phainon second-guess asking, long enough for him to think maybe he shouldn’t have.

Then, in a voice quiet as the rain outside, Mydei answered.

“It’s not cheap,” he said.

A beat.

“Nor reversible.”

Phainon’s mouth went dry. And yet—he smiled.

A little lopsided, a little reckless.

“I’m not in the habit of changing my mind.”

Mydei’s gaze didn’t waver. He said nothing else. Just went back to his work, the faintest ghost of something unreadable crossing his expression

before it was gone.

The candlelight flickered.

And somewhere, a phantom fingertip ghosted the curve of Phainon’s neck.

The hours in Castrum Kelethra had a way of bleeding together. The outside world, with its clean air and working clocks, felt like a rumor in here.

Phainon leaned his elbows against the counter, watching as Mydei worked.

The materials weren’t like anything he’d ever seen — slender coils of metal that shimmered with a strange oil-slick sheen, threads of color that looked black until the light caught them, then turned deep, ancient reds and tarnished golds.

Mydei moved with the steady focus of someone performing a ritual. His fingers coaxed the pieces together, fitting them into a delicate framework. Every now and then, the engraving tool at his side would twitch—moving in a tight, mechanical scrape across the locket’s surface without Mydei’s hand on it.

Phainon frowned.

He could’ve sworn it moved on its own.

And then it was still.

Mydei’s fingers casually reclaiming it, as though nothing odd had happened.

I need to stop breathing this air.

Phainon let out a slow breath and let his gaze wander—the shelves crowded with tiny glass lockets, each one catching the flicker of candles. But one caught his eye.

He leaned forward.

Inside the warped reflection of a pale oval locket, a face stared back at him.

It wasn’t his.

Not warped, not shifted.

A stranger’s face. Hollow-eyed. Watching him through the glass.

Phainon jerked back with a sharp inhale, blinking hard.

When he looked again, it was gone.

Just his own startled face, and the flickering room behind him.

“You alright?” Mydei’s voice cut in—casual, but with the barest thread of interest.

Phainon shook his head quickly, forcing a crooked grin. “Yeah. Yeah, just… these things’ve got character, huh?”

Mydei hummed, unreadable.

The shopkeeper lifted the finished locket between his fingers. It was beautiful—wrong in ways Phainon couldn’t name, delicate and ancient-looking, the metal’s surface catching the light like dark water.

Without ceremony, Mydei reached across the counter and pressed it into Phainon’s palm.

The warmth was immediate.

A pleasant, almost living heat against his skin.

Then it turned sharp.

Burning.

Phainon’s breath hitched, his fingers tightening reflexively around it as the searing heat bit into his flesh.

His gaze snapped up to Mydei.

The shopkeeper wasn’t smiling.

But he wasn’t indifferent, either.

His eyes fixed on Phainon’s face—watching the flicker of pain, the flush rising in his cheeks, the sharp edge of his breath leaving him. Not cruel… but utterly enthralled. Like an artist seeing something rare take shape.

Phainon forced a shaky laugh, trying to play it off. “Guess it’s… fresh.”

Mydei didn’t blink.

“Some things leave a mark,” he murmured.

“Better you know that now.”

He let the words hang heavy between them, the candlelight guttering around them both.

The warmth in Phainon’s palm didn’t fade. If anything, it seemed to burrow deeper, like the metal wasn’t cooling so much as settling into him.

His head swam, a lazy, tilting sort of dizziness that made the edges of the room soften and warp. The scent of the place seemed to crawl into his lungs and stick there.

Phainon reached out, steadying himself against the nearest display case, palm slick against the glass.

Okay… yeah. That’s enough weird for tonight.

He caught Mydei’s eyes through the haze. The shopkeeper had paused, leaning a hip against the workbench, arms crossed. That unreadable expression still fixed on him—half impatient, half… something else.

“You should head home,” Mydei said at last, not unkind.

Phainon chuckled weakly, waving a hand like he could brush the dizziness off. “Yeah… think you might be right for once.”

He made for the door, clutching the locket tight in his hand, the metal still hot enough to thrum against his skin.

“See you tomorrow, Mydei,” Phainon managed with a grin, glancing back over his shoulder.

Mydei didn’t answer.

Didn’t move.

Just watched him go, the shadows clinging a little too tightly around him. And Phainon, too lightheaded to notice, stepped out into the night.

The brass bell chimed once — though no one touched it.

And Mydei’s gaze lingered on the spot where Phainon had stood long after the door swung shut.

The heat wouldn’t leave him.

Phainon lay sprawled on his bed, one arm thrown over his eyes, sheets tangled around his legs, skin damp with sweat. The ceiling above him blurred and swam, the dark corners of his room thick with strange shapes his mind was too feverish to properly name. He could feel the pulse of it—that *thing*—buried in his palm like a second heartbeat.

The locket.

It sat on his nightstand, its chain spilling over the edge like spilled thread. The metal caught the low amber light of the streetlamp outside his window, gleaming dull and wet. Even from a foot away, he swore he could feel it watching him.

His stomach twisted, breath hitching, the residual warmth of it crawling through his veins like syrup. He shouldn’t have brought it home. Should’ve

left it on the counter, called it a weird, fever-dream sort of night and promised himself not to set foot in that cursed shop again.

But he hadn’t.

And now here he was, burning from the inside out.

He turned his head toward it, lips parting, a shudder working down his spine like fingers brushing along it. The air was thick with a scent he couldn’t name—something earthy and old, with the sharp bite of rain-soaked stone and a sweetness that was *too human.*

And beneath it… something familiar.

Without thinking, Phainon reached out. His fingers brushed the locket and it was still warm, almost feverishly so, like a body recently abandoned. The second his skin made contact, the heat spiked, an electric thrum that zipped up his wrist and pooled in his chest.

And then he smelled it.

Not just in the air now—but sharp and overwhelming, pouring off the locket in waves.

Phainon’s breath left him in a rough sound, throat bobbing as his head tipped back, eyes fluttering shut. The scent clung to the back of his throat, thick and cloying, and for a terrifying moment he could taste it.

Flesh. Salt. Something metallic.

And behind it—the sharp, electric press of a mouth against his.

It wasn’t memory. He knew that much. It wasn’t a dream either.

It was *now*.

A phantom kiss, rough and sure, lips dragging against his, teeth catching on his lower lip—not a promise, not a question, just *taking*. The sensation dragged a raw, aching sound from Phainon’s throat before he could stop it.

His other hand gripped the sheet, knuckles bone-white.

The touch didn’t stop there.

Fingers—he swore there were fingers—ghosted against the hollow of his throat, tracing the frantic jump of his pulse. The phantom heat of a mouth followed, pressing at the sensitive skin there, teeth scraping, tongue soothing. It was vivid enough to make him arch, his entire body tensing, nerves screaming.

“F-Fuck…”

It slipped out, ragged, half a prayer, half a curse.

He should’ve dropped the locket.

But instead, his fingers tightened around it, drawing it to his chest, pressing it against the skin there like he could anchor himself to it, though it was the very thing unraveling him.

The room tilted again, shadows rippling.

The scent grew stronger—something feral threaded through it now, older than the shop, older than the city. It felt alive, this thing in his hand, like it was breathing, like it had *found him.*

And Phainon, shame burning just beneath the fever, felt his body betray him. His skin hypersensitive, every drag of air over it electric. The ghost of a hand at his throat trailed lower, leaving a burning path in its wake.

Another breath hitched.

He bit his lip hard enough to taste blood.

The ceiling above him rippled, and in the wavering darkness, he thought he saw a shape—lean, sharp-edged, familiar in the way a nightmare is, like something seen once in childhood and buried until now.

His heart rattled painfully.

Another phantom kiss, softer this time, at the corner of his mouth.

It was impossible.

And it was happening.

He didn’t call for help. Couldn’t. Didn’t want to.

Somewhere deep in his bones, Phainon knew this was no accident. That scent—his scent—shouldn’t have existed in that shop, shouldn’t have been bottled, shouldn’t have burned so sweetly.

But it had.

And it was too late now.

His hand trembled as he clutched the locket tighter, sweat slicking his skin. The phantom touch pressed him down into the mattress, not cruelly—but possessively.

Like it had claimed him.

Phainon’s lips parted again, a raw sound escaping as he fought to stay present, to remember what was real. But real felt thin, stretched like old silk, and whatever this was—it was winning.

He shuddered violently.

The scent faded just a touch, the phantom touch lifting like a lover pulling away, leaving him cold, bereft, and desperate.

He opened his eyes.

Nothing.

Just his dim room, the faint hum of a streetlamp, the city breathing beyond his walls.

His pulse throbbed in his ears.

The locket in his palm cooled, metal settling into the ordinary chill of brass.

But Phainon could still taste it—salt and iron and something bitter-sweet—and the ghost of those lips lingered on his skin.

Somewhere in the city, far from his reach, a bell chimed.

“Hello? You dead or just sulking?”

Mydei’s voice cut through the thick, heady air of Castrum Kelethra like a knife. He didn’t even look up from the counter, fingers deftly threading a delicate chain through the tiny hinge of a locket that shimmered like oil in water.

Phainon didn’t answer.

Didn’t crack a joke. Didn’t toss back a flirty jab or make some comment about Mydei’s endless charm.

He stood just inside the threshold, the bell above the door silent despite having clearly been triggered. Shoulders stiff, hair damp from the wet outside, eyes fixed somewhere on a high shelf past Mydei’s head. And for the first time since his very first visit, he wasn’t smiling.

Mydei’s brow twitched.

He set the chain down, finally glancing up. “You get lost on the way to your own funeral, or what?”

Still nothing.

The usual spark was gone, replaced by a distant sort of quiet that made the shop feel even heavier than normal.

“Phainon.”

That, at least, earned a flicker. A glance. Fleeting.

“Wow,” Mydei snorted, leaning against the workbench. “Didn’t peg you for the brooding type. Or are you hungover on cheap whiskey and bad decisions?”

Phainon finally spoke, voice low and rough. “Something like that.”

It was a bad lie. Even Mydei could tell, though he wasn’t one to press where it wasn’t profitable. He let the quiet settle a beat too long before reaching for a locket case on a nearby shelf.

“Look, if you came back just to haunt me, don’t bother. I already got enough dead things in here.”

Phainon’s lips twitched—almost a smile, not quite. He dragged a hand through his hair, still avoiding Mydei’s eyes.

“I was just…checking in. See if you had anything new.”

That earned a sardonic hum.

“Whole world out there and you’re still sniffing around here. Must be a death wish. Or worse, boredom.”

Mydei moved around the counter, setting a tray of fresh-finished lockets onto a display. One of them pulsed faintly, the glassy surface catching the light in a way that made Phainon’s stomach knot.

He made the mistake of glancing toward the door as it swung open.

A customer passed by him on their way out. Their steps too soft. The skin of their face stretched too tight, eyes glassy, pupils a pinprick too wide. Phainon’s breath hitched as they brushed by, the faint scent of dried lavender and grave dirt following them out.

He swallowed hard.

Mydei didn’t seem to notice—or care.

Instead, the shopkeeper plucked a locket from the tray and turned back to him. “So. You still have it, right?”

Phainon froze.

His fingers instinctively brushed the pocket of his jacket, where the small, cold weight of last night’s locket rested against his palm. It was quiet now. Dormant. But he still swore it watched him.

“Yeah,” he managed, voice tight.

Mydei stepped closer. Slowly. An almost casual prowl that made the hairs on the back of Phainon’s neck rise. Close enough that the scent of the shop thickened, something in it sharper now—like cut metal under velvet.

“Good,” Mydei murmured. His eyes stayed steady on Phainon’s face, sharp and unreadable. “It’s a keepsake. Yours now. Won’t lose it, will you?”

The words landed heavier than they should have. Not a question. Not a suggestion. A claim.

Phainon instinctively took half a step back, flinching before he could stop himself. His throat felt dry, a thousand things he wanted to say jamming up against the weight of last night. That taste. Those phantom touches. The burn of the locket in his skin.

Mydei’s expression didn’t shift, but something in his gaze glinted like dark glass catching firelight. It pinned Phainon in place, held him there.

“Relax,” the shopkeeper drawled, pulling back at last. “You look like I tried to kiss you or something.”

Phainon let out a strangled, too-loud laugh that cracked apart in the middle.

“Yeah,” he muttered, scrubbing a hand over his face. “God, wouldn’t that be a horror.”

But his heart pounded against his ribs, the locket a weight against his palm even through his jacket.

And behind Mydei, another customer came in. Silent. Wrong.

Phainon didn’t look this time. He didn’t need to.

Phainon’s gaze drifted—half by accident, half by some ugly, gnawing instinct he didn’t want to name—to a narrow display case tucked into the far corner of the shop. He didn’t remember seeing it before, though that meant nothing in this place.

It was an old thing, the glass smudged with age, the wood dark and cracked like brittle bone. Inside, lined in black velvet, sat rows of lockets.

Tiny, delicate, intricate.

Each one faintly glowing.

Each one…pulsing.

Phainon’s stomach turned. His hand rose to the weight around his neck, the cool metal of his locket pressing against his skin like a brand.

He’d suspected it before. Some nagging voice in the back of his head whispering it the night it burned his palm and left that mark he swore wasn’t there anymore. But seeing it now—lined up like a trophy or a tombstone, no different than the rest except for how he could feel its pulse under his fingertips—confirmed it.

His.

The same shimmer in the glass, the same warmth even now.

Phainon’s throat tightened.

He turned, ready to demand an answer, something, anything—

But the shop was already empty.

Mydei was by the door, hands on the latch. His apron was gone. The lights had dimmed without Phainon noticing. The air felt thicker, heavier, like

something holding its breath.

“We’re closing up early,” Mydei said, voice mild. No sign of the irritation or snark he usually wore. Just calm. Crisp.

Phainon blinked. “Wait, what? Since when do you—”

“Since now.”

Mydei turned the lock with a quiet click. The last customer—the wrong one—was nowhere to be seen. The faint, persistent ticking of the old clock behind the counter sounded like a heartbeat.

“But—”

Mydei’s gaze slid to him. Unreadable. Unmoving. And then—unexpectedly—a small, thin smile. Not cruel. Not kind. Something in between, balanced on a razor’s edge.

“See you tomorrow, Phainon.”

The words landed too soft. Too certain. Like it wasn’t a question.

He tilted his head just a fraction, that smile never reaching his eyes.

Phainon swallowed hard, something inside him stuttering.

“…Yeah,” he muttered, brushing past him, careful not to touch. “Sure.”

The bell still didn’t ring when the door opened.

Outside, the street was empty. The rain had stopped hours ago, but the air still tasted wet and heavy. Phainon adjusted the locket against his chest, fingers tracing the edge.

It didn’t burn anymore.

For now.

And he didn’t have the nerve to look back.

End Notes

Alright feel free to point out any repetitive words or mistakes cause not even gonna lie, my ass did NOT proofread it. Anyway though, hope you guys enjoyed <3

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